

Study Guide & Program Companion

How to bring the Ten Commandments of Ethical Online Behavior to your camp, congregation, school, or family: what is in the kit, how to choose a program, and how to lead it well.

Digital Mensches pairs ten commandments of ethical online behavior with the Jewish values behind them and current research on what teens actually experience online. The document is a living draft: every program run and every piece of feedback shapes the next version. This companion helps you pick the right program for your setting and lead it with confidence. All materials, and every way to send feedback, live at techrabbi.org/digital-mensches.

What This Program Is For

Before the logistics, the point. Everything else in this kit, the timings, the group sizes, the five program formats, exists to serve what follows. If a decision you make in the room serves these ends better than the run sheet does, follow the room. That is not permission to wing it. It is the standard by which to judge your own adaptations.

Enduring Understandings

What we want a participant to still hold a year from now, long after they have forgotten the number ten.

1. Jewish tradition already has language for what happens online. The situations are new. The obligations are old.
2. What I do on a screen reaches real people, and one of those people is me.
3. Ethical choices online are judgment calls I make, not rules handed to me. Wrestling with them is itself the Jewish move.
4. Technology, artificial intelligence included, can serve human dignity or corrode it, and which one it does depends on choices people make, including mine.
5. I am allowed to disagree with any of this, and saying why is part of the practice, not a departure from it.

Essential Questions

- What does it mean to be a mensch when nobody else is in the room?
- Which of my obligations to other people change online, and which stay exactly the same?
- What am I still responsible for when a machine does part of the work?
- Where does what I am entitled to know end, and where does someone else's privacy begin?

Session objectives

By the end of any program in this kit, a participant should be able to:

- name at least two Jewish values from the document and apply each to a specific situation from their own online life;
- take a position on at least one digital dilemma and give a reason for it;

- state one thing in the document they disagree with, or one thing it fails to address;
- leave with one commitment, or one question, they can carry out of the room.

THE STANDARD, STATED PLAINLY

Two values discussed well beats ten values mentioned. A group that spends the whole session on *g'neivat da'at* and leaves arguing about what counts as theft has met the objectives. A group that touches all ten and remembers none has not. Coverage is not the goal, and the ten are not a checklist.

WHAT THIS IS NOT

This is not an internet safety class, a screen time intervention, or a lesson with a right answer at the end. Participants who arrive skeptical, or who barely use social media, are not outside the conversation. Their skepticism is data, and the document is a draft that their pushback is meant to change.

How you will know it worked

You cannot measure whether someone behaves differently online three months later, and this kit does not pretend to. What you can notice in the room:

- a participant reaches for a Jewish value without being prompted;
- someone changes their mind out loud, or refuses to, and says why;
- the disagreement stays respectful, which is the content as much as the discussion is;
- somebody asks a question you cannot answer.

What Is in the Kit

The Ten Commandments document. The full text: each commandment with its Jewish value, sources, a reflection question, and "What Teens Are Saying" research.

Camper handout. All ten commandments condensed to four pages, with the chevrotah study questions on the last page. This is the piece participants hold.

Commandment posters. One page per commandment, for hanging around the room.

Scenario cards. Ten real-life dilemmas to cut apart; the engine of every program's best conversations. See the card list at the end of this guide.

Program guides. Five ready-to-run session plans, described below. Each is a standalone printable run sheet with a 45, 60, and 90 minute timing column.

Feedback forms. Participant slips (two quick questions), a one-page facilitator form, and an in-depth educator review worksheet.

Choosing a Program

Five programs, one document. They differ in who they are for, how the commandments arrive, and what the room needs to look like. Pick by your group and your space; every guide includes complete facilitator notes, scripts, and timing.

Program	Core move	Best for	Group (works best at)	Room
I. Poster Gallery	Participants browse the posters and choose their commandment	Teen groups with energy; ownership through choice	15-60	Wall space, room to spread out
II. Text Study Circle	Assigned chevrotah study; every commandment gets heard	Smaller teen groups; full coverage of the document	4-24	Any seated arrangement
III. Scenarios First	Wrestle with scenarios and write your own commandment before meeting the ten	Discovery-style learning; groups new to the document	9-40	Any room where huddles can talk
IV. Personal Reflection	Private written exercises on your own online life	Adults and staff preparing to lead; also works solo	Any, incl. 1	Anywhere quiet
V. Feedback Workshop	Structured review of the document with recorded recommendations	Educators, clergy, committees, staff teams	3-20	Tables to write at

GROUP SIZES ARE A GUIDE, NOT A GATE

The numbers above describe where each format runs most easily, not a minimum you have to clear. Every one of these programs can be adapted down or up, and each program guide now says how. A facilitator at one of our pilots wanted to run Poster Gallery with nine participants, read "fifteen to sixty," and chose a different program instead. She was right that nine is small for a gallery walk and right that she could have run it anyway, by sending pairs from poster to poster in rotation. Read the number as information about the room, then decide as the educator you are.

A RECOMMENDED SEQUENCE FOR STAFF TEAMS

Run **IV. Personal Reflection** with your staff first, so the adults have the conversation with themselves before leading it. Then run **I, II, or III** with your teens, chosen by group size and room. Afterward, gather leadership for **V. Feedback Workshop** and send us what you learned.

Facilitation Tips

Set the tone. Digital ethics is a rapidly evolving area where even experts disagree. This is a learning community, not a test. Model vulnerability by sharing your own digital struggles.

Honor multiple perspectives. Participants may range from tech-skeptical to tech-enthusiastic. Create space for all of them. The Jewish tradition of *machloket l'shem shamayim*, disagreement for the sake of heaven, is a valuable frame.

Don't panic about AI. You don't need to be an expert to lead these conversations. The questions about honesty, effort, dignity, stewardship, and connection are deeply human questions Jewish tradition has wrestled with for millennia. Lead with the values, not the technology.

Center youth voices. Include teens in every review you can. Most teens already use AI chatbots and know the day-to-day reality better than many adults.

Be concrete. Abstract principles become meaningful through specific stories and scenarios. Encourage participants to share real, anonymized examples from their own communities.

Avoid shame. Many adults feel embarrassed about their own online behavior or AI use. The goal is growth, not perfection; that is a deeply Jewish approach (*teshuvah* is always possible).

Follow up. Commit to a timeline for sending in feedback, and tell your community when the next version is coming. A review process without follow-through undermines trust.

The Scenario Cards at a Glance

A leader's reference to the ten cards. Any card works in any program; for a spread, mix people-focused and AI-focused cards.

The Screenshot PEOPLE – an embarrassing private message gets shared in a group chat.

The Rumor PEOPLE – a vague but clearly targeted negative post; comments pile on.

The AI Essay AI – "I just used AI to help organize my thoughts." Where is the line?

The AI Companion AI – a chatbot that "understands me better than my friends do."

The Deepfake AI – a classmate's face on an inappropriate image, "just a joke."

The Stolen Art AI – "I didn't steal anything. The AI made it."

The Environmental Question AI – if AI uses so much energy and water, is using it ethical at all?

The Misinformation Share PEOPLE + AI – a dramatic story turns out to be AI-generated; it has already been reposted.

The Pile-On PEOPLE + AI – dozens attack an unpopular opinion, some with AI-generated mockery.

The Comparison Trap PEOPLE + AI – feeling terrible after scrolling a "perfect," AI-enhanced feed.

Sharing Feedback

Digital Mensches gets better every time someone tells us what happened. After any session, go to **techrabbi.org/digital-mensches** and photograph your paper forms, upload files, type rough notes, record a voice memo, or let our AI interviewer ask you about it. Printable forms for participants, facilitators, and educators are on the same page.

An Important Note

This document was developed with the assistance of AI tools for research, drafting, and revision, modeling the kind of transparent, human-guided AI use these commandments advocate.